Mansur died. Worse, it is possible that many of the cold hearts celebrating Shah Mansur's demise had conspired to bring it about. Those incriminating letters that provoked Akbar's fury would turn out to be forgeries.

Historians suspect various noblemen – including Shah Mansur's colleague, Todar Mal – of masterminding the plot, though it is generally agreed that the conspiracy was a wide-ranging collaboration. 'Most, nay all, of the Amirs, who had received many annoyances from Shah Mansur, were longing for his fall,' writes Badauni. 'With one consent they exerted themselves to secure his execution.' Badauni himself had no sympathy for the poor vizier, writing balefully that Shah Mansur's 'numerous oppressions . . . formed the halter round his neck, and may it remain clinging there till the day of Resurrection'.

Only Akbar regretted it. Abul Fazl quotes the emperor saying that 'the thread of accounting dropped from the hand' after Shah Mansur's execution. It wasn't only selfish concerns that upset Akbar; it was the injustice that he, *sultan-i-adil*, provider of justice to his people, had inflicted on his terrified accountant. Badauni writes that Akbar regretted his death and was 'very much grieved' when he discovered the forgeries on account of which he had had Shah Mansur executed.

At the time, however, marching ever closer towards Kabul and the inevitable confrontation with his half-brother, Akbar was willing to let the threads of accountancy slip, as long as the reins of his own destiny remained firmly in his grasp. He was taking no chances.

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On 24 May 1581, Akbar camped on the banks of the Indus river. It may have occurred to him that, within the last fifty years, both his father and grandfather had stood on the other side of these blue waters, calculating their chances of conquering Hindustan. He may have remembered sitting with Humayun in the light of a setting moon as his father blessed him with his breath. But now, Akbar was no adventurer, no exiled king seeking his fortune; he was master of a vast realm, sending word to his little brother, who clung to precarious independence in the family's old seat: surrender, or be swallowed whole.

Having camped outside Lahore for about twenty days that spring, '[shooting] arrows at an imaginary target', Muhammad Hakim had fled at